



RCCG OCEANIA

Bible Foundations

ENCOURAGED BY THE LIVING WORD

AT A GLANCE

BIG IDEA

"In the beginning was the Word" (John 1:1) sets the foundation for why Scripture is not optional for faith and life. Psalm 1 portrays the blessed life as rooted and fruitful through delight in God's instruction. Psalm 38 voices the honest need of a suffering heart that turns toward God rather than away from Him. This study encourages steady trust and direction through God's Word.

PRIMARY PASSAGES

John 1:1

Psalms 1

Psalms 38

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Receive encouragement by returning to God's Word as your starting point (John 1:1).
- Pursue the "blessed" path by delighting in and meditating on God's instruction (Psalms 1).
- Expect rootedness and fruitfulness when your life is planted in God's Word (Psalms 1).
- Bring real pain and conviction to God honestly, not hiding your condition (Psalms 38).
- Let the Word shape your hope when you feel weighed down or weak (John 1:1; Psalms 38).

INTRODUCTION

Encouragement that lasts must be anchored to something stronger than changing emotions and shifting circumstances. Scripture presents God's Word as foundational, life-giving, and steady. John 1:1 points to the primacy of "the Word." Psalm 1 describes two paths and shows what stability looks like when a person delights in God's instruction. Psalm 38 provides a model for honest, prayerful dependence when suffering and conviction are real. This study guides a return to Scripture as the place where faith finds direction, stability, and hope.

SCRIPTURE READING

- **John 1:1** — This verse establishes the identity and primacy of "the Word." It sets a foundation for faith and encouragement by directing attention to what is ultimate and trustworthy from the beginning.
- **Psalms 1** — This psalm contrasts two ways of life: one shaped by wicked counsel and one shaped by God's instruction. It highlights delight and meditation as the pathway to stability and fruitfulness.
- **Psalms 38** — This psalm models prayer in distress and conviction. It shows a suffering heart speaking honestly to God, refusing to drift into silence or self-reliance.

KEY POINTS

1. **BEGIN WHERE GOD BEGINS: THE WORD** — Encouragement starts with a clear foundation. John 1:1 places “the Word” at the beginning, showing that faith is not built on personal strength or passing feelings. When life is confusing or painful, returning to the Word re-centers what is true. Instead of letting circumstances define reality, Scripture reminds the heart that God’s truth remains steady. Anchoring in the Word means treating Scripture as essential rather than optional. It becomes the starting point for perspective, prayer, and decision-making.

- Begin each day by reading a short portion of Scripture before seeking other inputs.
- When discouraged, write down one truth from John 1:1 and use it as a focus for prayer.
- Before making a significant choice, pause to ask: “What does God’s Word emphasize that should shape this decision?”
- Choose one consistent time and place to meet with God in His Word and protect it.

Scripture: John 1:1

2. **CHOOSE THE BLESSED PATH** — Psalm 1 describes two paths: one shaped by ungodly influence and one shaped by delight in God’s instruction. Encouragement grows as a person chooses the path that aligns desires, habits, and decisions with what God says. The psalm is practical: it speaks about counsel received, patterns adopted, and the company kept. A “blessed” life is not presented as effortless, but as guided—protected from the slow drift that comes from walking, standing, and sitting in what pulls the heart away from God. Delight in God’s instruction is central. This is more than reading words; it is welcoming God’s direction as good, trustworthy, and life-giving.

- Identify one voice or influence that regularly pulls you away from God’s instruction and set a boundary for it.
- Ask God to grow your desire for His instruction, especially in areas where obedience feels difficult.
- Choose one command, promise, or warning from Psalm 1 and reflect on how it should shape your week.
- Practice replacing unhelpful counsel with Scripture by reading Psalm 1 when you feel pressured to compromise.

Scripture: Psalms 1

KEY POINTS (CONT.)

3. STAY ROOTED THROUGH ONGOING MEDITATION — Psalm 1 uses the picture of a tree planted by streams of water to describe stability and fruitfulness. The image emphasizes continuity: the tree is not occasionally near water; it is planted where nourishment is steady. Meditation on God's instruction "day and night" points to ongoing engagement. This does not mean constant reading without responsibilities, but a life where Scripture remains present—remembered, repeated, and applied throughout the day. Encouragement is sustained when Scripture becomes a steady source of nourishment. The goal is not merely information but formation: a rooted life that endures and bears fruit in season.

- Memorize a short portion of Psalm 1 and review it at set points in the day.
- Choose one verse to carry into the day and return to it during moments of stress or decision.
- Keep a simple record of how Scripture is shaping you: one insight, one correction, and one encouragement.
- Build a rhythm of re-reading Psalm 1 regularly to evaluate whether your life is rooted in God's instruction.

Scripture: Psalms 1

4. PRAY HONESTLY IN DISTRESS — Psalm 38 shows that encouragement is not denial of pain. It is the courage to bring distress and conviction to God with honesty. The psalm gives words for times when the heart feels overwhelmed, weak, or burdened. Rather than hiding, the suffering person turns toward God. Honest prayer includes confession, lament, and dependence—acknowledging need without pretending strength. This kind of prayer keeps the heart connected to God when suffering threatens isolation. It also allows Scripture to guide the tone of prayer: truthful, humble, and seeking God's help.

- Use Psalm 38 as a prayer guide: read a section and respond to God with your own honest words.
- Name your distress plainly before God, including any conviction that needs confession.
- If you feel spiritually numb, keep praying with the psalm's words until your own words return.
- Ask God for strength to turn toward Him immediately when pain rises, rather than withdrawing.

Scripture: Psalms 38

GROUP DISCUSSION

Tip: Use these questions to guide the group from seeing → understanding → applying.

OBSERVATION

- In John 1:1, what is stated about “the Word,” and how does the verse place the Word at the beginning?
- In Psalm 1, what repeated actions describe the path that leads away from blessing (walking, standing, sitting)?
- What does Psalm 1 say the blessed person delights in and meditates on?
- What image does Psalm 1 use to describe the person rooted in God’s instruction, and what results are mentioned?
- In Psalm 38, what kinds of experiences are brought into prayer (distress, weakness, conviction), and how openly are they expressed?

INTERPRETATION

- How does starting with John 1:1 reshape what you treat as most reliable when life feels unstable?
- Why might Psalm 1 connect counsel, patterns, and companionship to spiritual direction and encouragement?
- What does “meditating day and night” suggest about how Scripture is meant to function in everyday life?
- How does the tree imagery in Psalm 1 help explain stability and fruitfulness over time rather than instant change?
- What does Psalm 38 teach about the relationship between honest confession/lament and continued dependence on God?

APPLICATION

- What is one practical step that would help you begin where God begins—making Scripture your starting point each day?
- Which “path” described in Psalm 1 do your recent choices most resemble, and what needs to change this week?
- What habit could help Scripture remain present throughout your day (remembered, repeated, applied) rather than occasional?
- When distress or conviction rises, what is your default response, and how can Psalm 38 reshape it into honest prayer?
- What specific encouragement do you need right now, and which of these passages will you return to for direction and hope?

PRAYER FOCUS

- Ask God to deepen your delight in Scripture and make His Word your daily starting point.
- Pray to be rooted and fruitful through ongoing meditation on God’s instruction.
- Ask for discernment and strength to reject ungodly counsel and choose the blessed path.
- Pray for grace to turn toward God with honest confession and dependence in times of distress.

NEXT STEP

Establish a consistent rhythm of reading, reflecting on, and praying Scripture each day, beginning with John 1:1, Psalm 1, and Psalm 38.

CONCLUSION

Encouragement becomes steady when life is anchored in the Word of God. John 1:1 calls for a foundation that begins with the Word. Psalm 1 invites deliberate choices that lead to a blessed, rooted, fruitful life through delight and meditation in God's instruction. Psalm 38 provides language for honest prayer in distress, keeping the heart turned toward God. A life shaped by Scripture is not untouched by hardship, but it is guided, nourished, and sustained by God's truth.